slowly. The economic asymmetry between India and China is growing. In 1988, when Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi paid an official visit to Beijing, Deng Xiaoping had envisioned an Asian century which would be shaped by both India and China. Today, for China, the Asian century is exclusively a Chinese century.

All these dramatic changes have taken place under the leadership of the CPC, and it is therefore worthwhile to consider how the Party and its leadership have evolved over the 100 years that have elapsed since its founding in 1921. How has the Party assessed the domestic and external situation in China at various historical junctures? How has its world view changed over the years? And what clues does this history provide for the likely trajectory of China during the current century? These are key questions to be explored.

The CPC has inherited the Chinese imperial tradition, claiming to have the mandate to rule over China, even if legitimacy is claimed from the ‘people’ and not from heaven. And yet, the CPC leadership has manipulated imperial symbols in subtle ways, to place Party rule in direct succession to empire. After entry into Beijing, the senior leadership moved into the imperial buildings of the Forbidden City and appeared before the ‘people’ only in carefully orchestrated and politically curated public events. The CPC was also sensitive to people being influenced by superstitions. In 1976, Mao’s death was preceded by a series of unusual events, including the devastating Tangshan earthquake. The Party media was full of articles condemning the circulation of rumours that these unusual events presaged a withdrawal of the mandate to rule from Mao and the CPC. Throughout Chinese history, each dynasty rewrote the history of what had gone before, underscoring the inevitability of its succession and the legitimacy of its rule. This was undertaken with a ruthlessness and violence that is unique to China. The CPC not only inherited this tradition but refined it in many ways. Deposed leaders were airbrushed out of pictures, and their denigration would be total.

The CPC has been through several significant ideological and leadership transitions, and how the Party has itself interpreted those changes is a useful